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A tale of contributors and contributing

Suman stresses the importance of giving back to the community. “Using open source means you’re hiring the whole world as your support system. Initially, this is a consumer mindset, but once you’re in that system, you will automatically give back. Many organisations contribute back in terms of monetary support or training others. It’s inspiring to see people across the world come together to build something impactful,” he shares.

Suman believes there are many ways of contributing to the community. “People without coding backgrounds, who just use a particular open source package, can always contribute to documentation. Attending community meetups and sharing knowledge is also

an indirect way of contributing to the open source world,” he says.

Another interesting way of contributing, and one that Suman is currently involved in, is creating code samples for different books. “Currently, I’m helping build the code samples for a book called *‘Building Large Language Models from Scratch’* by Sebastian Raschka, a renowned professor in machine learning and applied sciences and a researcher at Lightning AI. The author has written the code samples, and others can raise PR requests suggesting additions or modifications. These could be documentation changes or actual code contributions,” he elucidates.

Suman shares that there are many books about machine learning and the community, both in the tech and non-tech fields. A few of his favourites

include *‘Probabilistic Machine Learning’* by Kevin Murphy, which he calls the bible for machine learning, and *‘Understanding Deep Learning’* by Simon J.D. Prince. Among non-technical books, he suggests *‘Community in a Box’*, authored by his colleague Mark Birch. “It’s about how to build an event-driven professional community, and it’s an insightful book,” he says.

Along with the suggestions, Suman shares a warning for all learners. “We live in a world of reels and short videos, but these kinds of subjects cannot be learned in 30 or 40 seconds. You have to spend time and have patience to learn about these topics,” he cautions.

With such a vast community, Suman has a list of leaders he looks up to, the foremost being Neependra Khare (Docker captain), Ajeet Singh Raina (Docker captain), and Vivek Raja (an AWS hero). “Vivek created the AWS user group in Madurai, building everything from the ground up,” he says, sharing his association with Vivek. “I met him through the community at one of the user group meetups. Vivek was contributing to various meetups and groups, and ended up joining the startup he was contributing to, along with his other contributions to the open source community. He was hosting events and speaking at tech conferences. Today, he’s the vice president of products at that company, working in the healthcare and neuroscience domain, and he’s also an AWS hero. He’s well-known globally in the fields of machine learning and community work,” narrates Suman, highlighting the power of open source, the community, and their role in career growth.

For Suman, open source doesn’t come with a minimum eligibility criterion. “The minute you take the first step and contribute to the ecosystem, you become a community member. Once you are in this kind of ecosystem, you end up elevating your career and your life by sharing and receiving knowledge,” he concludes. **END** 🐧